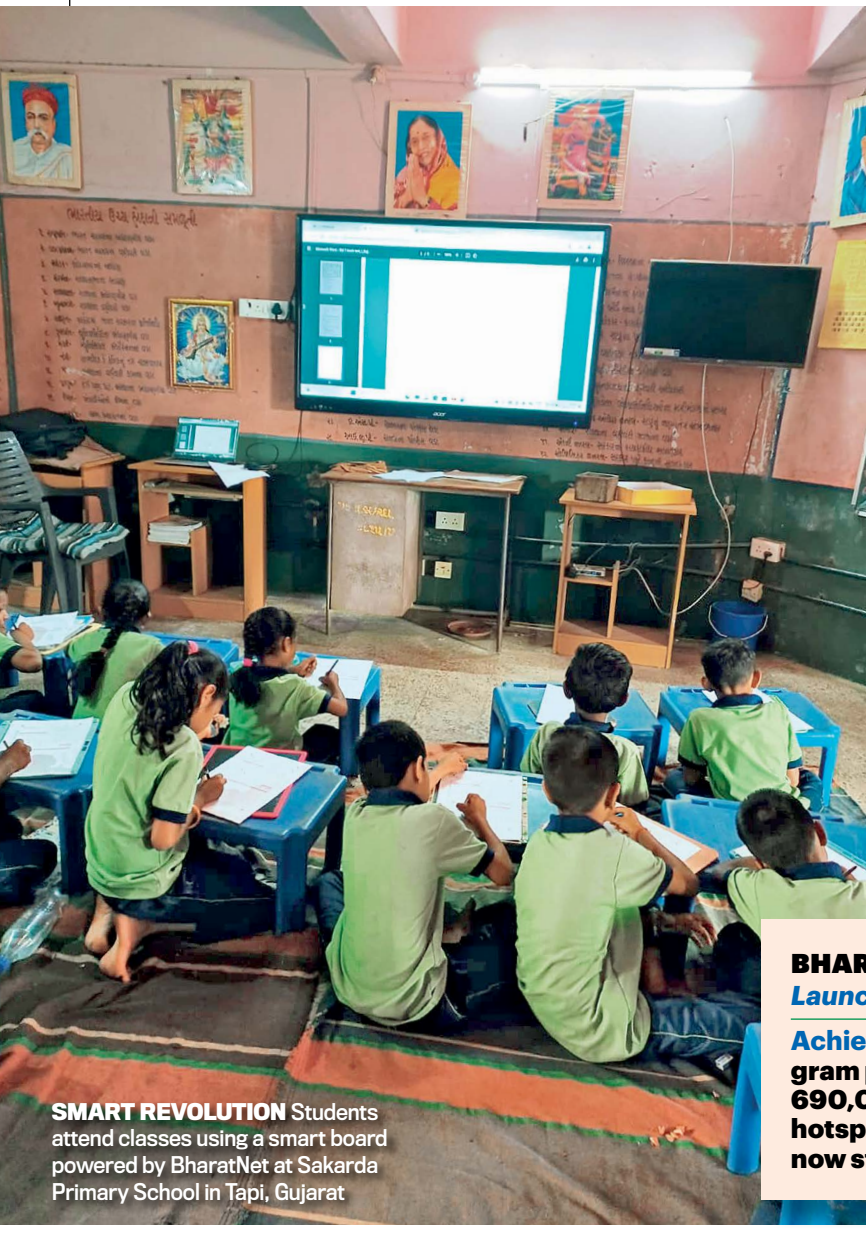
BRIDGING THE DIGITAL DIVIDE

An ambitious project that will provide affordable high-speed internet across rural India, BharatNet is leveraging broadband connectivity to uplift communities

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR



SMART REVOLUTION Students attend classes using a smart board powered by BharatNet at Sakarda Primary School in Tapi, Gujarat

THE DRUDGERY

Even as late as 2017, when India became the world's largest consumer of mobile data thanks to Jio, the vast majority of its villages had limited or no internet connectivity, leaving them aloof from the nation's fast digital growth. Public Wi-Fi hotspots were nearly non-existent. Citizens relied on unstable and slow mobile networks—average speeds stood at 8 Mbps back then. The digital divide wasn't just about ease of access to the internet; it had real economic and social consequences. The lack of high-speed internet kept new forms of basic services—e-governance schemes, telemedicine, online education—out of the reach of remote villages. Millions of intended beneficiaries couldn't even apply for government programmes without travelling to a neighbouring town to access an internet cafe.

BHARATNET PROJECT
Launched in 2011-12

Achievement: As of Dec. 2024, 214,000+ gram panchayats connected with 690,000-km optical fibre, 104,500+ Wi-Fi hotspots installed. Broadband services now start at just Rs 99/month in rural areas